

GSS SPIRITUAL YEAR LECTURE NOTES

The Mission of St. Paul and Its Cultural Challenge

Good Shepherd Seminary | Catholic Archdiocese of Mount Hagen | Papua New Guinea

Course
GSS Theology /
Missiology

Topic
Mission of St. Paul &
Cultural Challenge

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1. WHO WAS SAINT PAUL?

Saint Paul, originally known as Saul of Tarsus, was one of the most influential figures in early Christianity. A Roman citizen trained in Pharisaic law, he first persecuted Christians before his dramatic encounter with Christ transformed him into history's greatest missionary.

1.1 Background

- Formerly Saul of Tarsus — zealous persecutor of Christians
 - Acts 9:1–2 — Saul breathing threats against the disciples
- A Pharisee trained rigorously in Jewish law
 - Philippians 3:5–6 — trained under Gamaliel
- A Roman citizen — a rare and powerful legal privilege
 - Acts 22:25–28 — citizenship protected him from flogging
- Converted after a dramatic encounter with the risen Christ
 - Acts 9:3–6 — blinded on the road to Damascus

Key Idea

God can transform a persecutor into a missionary. No one is beyond conversion.

2. PAUL'S MISSION PURPOSE

- Chosen by God to preach specifically to the Gentiles (non-Jews)
 - Acts 9:15 — "He is my chosen instrument to proclaim my name to the Gentiles"
- Formally commissioned and sent out as a missionary
 - Acts 13:2–3 — set apart by the Holy Spirit
- Focused on spreading the gospel beyond Jewish communities to all nations

Key Scriptures

Romans 1:16 — "For I am not ashamed of the gospel... it is the power of God for salvation to everyone who believes."

Matthew 28:19 — "Go therefore and make disciples of all nations." (The Great Commission)

3. PAUL'S MISSION STRATEGY

3a. Urban Evangelism

Paul deliberately targeted major cities as strategic centers of culture, trade, and communication.

- Cities visited: Corinth, Ephesus, Philippi, Thessalonica, Athens, Rome
- Strategy: influence centers of power to reach surrounding regions

3b. "Synagogue First" Approach

Paul typically began preaching in Jewish synagogues before extending to Gentile audiences.

Acts 17:1-2 — "As was his custom, Paul went into the synagogue, and on three Sabbath days he reasoned with them from the Scriptures."

3c. Cultural Adaptation

Paul adjusted his message, language, and approach depending on his audience — without compromising the gospel.

- To Jews: used Scripture, law, and prophecy
- To Greeks: used philosophy and natural theology (Acts 17:22-23)
- To all: became "all things to all people"

1 Corinthians 9:19-23 — "I have become all things to all people so that by all possible means I might save some."

3d. Church Planting & Follow-Up

- Established Christian communities in every city he visited
- Maintained contact through pastoral letters
- Examples: 1 Corinthians, Galatians, Philippians, Romans

4. CULTURAL CHALLENGES PAUL FACED

4a. Jewish vs. Gentile Conflict

The central tension: Must Gentile converts follow Jewish law (circumcision, dietary rules) to be saved?

- Many Jewish Christians said YES — the law is essential
- Paul argued NO — salvation is by grace through faith, not law

Galatians 2:16 — "A person is not justified by the works of the law, but by faith in Jesus Christ."

Acts 15:1-11 — The Council of Jerusalem resolved this dispute.

4b. Different Worldviews

Paul moved across radically different cultural-religious frameworks:

JEWISH AUDIENCE

GREEK AUDIENCE

ROMAN AUDIENCE

One God, Scripture-based monotheism, waiting for the Messiah

Philosophy, reason, many gods, Stoic and Epicurean traditions

Imperial authority, law, emperor worship, civic religion

Acts 17:22–23 — Paul at the Areopagus: "Men of Athens, I see that in every way you are very religious... the God you worship as unknown, I am going to proclaim to you."

4c. Idolatry and Pagan Religious Practices

- Greco-Roman world was filled with temples, statues, and religious festivals
- Preaching one God directly threatened deeply rooted local traditions
- In Ephesus, Paul's preaching even threatened the economy of idol-makers

Acts 19:23–27 — The Ephesus riot: silversmiths whose business was making idols of Artemis feared ruin.

4d. Persecution and Political Opposition

Paul faced systematic violence and legal persecution throughout his ministry:

- Imprisonment, beatings, stoning, shipwreck, and eventual execution in Rome
- Christianity seen as a dangerous sect threatening Roman social order
- Preaching a "Lord" other than Caesar was politically subversive

2 Corinthians 11:23–27 — Paul lists floggings, imprisonments, shipwrecks, and constant danger.

Acts 16:22–24 — Paul and Silas stripped, beaten, and thrown into prison in Philippi.

4e. Internal Church Problems

Even within Christian communities, serious problems threatened unity:

- Division: factions forming around different leaders
- Immorality: ethical failures in the community
- False teaching: distortions of the gospel
- Social tensions: rich vs. poor at the Lord's Supper

1 Corinthians 1:10 — "I appeal to you... that there be no divisions among you."

1 Corinthians 5:1–2 — Paul confronts immorality tolerated in the Corinthian church.

5. PAUL'S APPROACH TO CULTURE

Core Principle

"I have become all things to all people, so that by all possible means I might save some." — 1 Corinthians 9:22

Paul maintained a critical balance:

CULTURAL SENSITIVITY

- Understand local traditions

THEOLOGICAL CONSISTENCY

- Never compromise the gospel message

- Use appropriate language & analogies
- Respect audience's worldview
- Adapt method to context
- Keep Christ at the centre
- Maintain doctrinal truth
- Uphold unity of the Church

6. THEOLOGICAL EMPHASES

Salvation by Grace Through Faith

Ephesians 2:8-9 — "For it is by grace you have been saved, through faith—and this is not from yourselves, it is the gift of God—not by works, so that no one can boast."

Unity in Christ

Galatians 3:28 — "There is neither Jew nor Gentile, neither slave nor free, nor is there male and female, for you are all one in Christ Jesus."

Life in the Spirit

Romans 8:1-2 — "Therefore, there is now no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus, because through Christ Jesus the law of the Spirit who gives life has set you free."

7. LESSONS FOR TODAY

- Cross-cultural mission requires genuine understanding of the local context
- Respect local traditions while remaining faithful to the truth of the gospel
- Build unity among diverse people without erasing legitimate cultural differences
- Perseverance in the face of opposition is part of authentic mission
- Paul's model applies not only in religion but in education, development, and leadership

Relevance for Papua New Guinea: The Church in PNG faces similar challenges — preaching the gospel across hundreds of language groups, diverse tribal cultures, and varied worldviews. Paul's model of contextualised evangelism is directly applicable.

DISCUSSION & EXAMINATION QUESTIONS

Question	Scripture Ref.	Type
Who was Paul before his conversion?	Acts 9:1-2	Short Answer
What was Paul's mission according to Acts 9:15?	Acts 9:15	Short Answer
What strategy did Paul use when entering a new city?	Acts 17:1-2	Short Answer
What does 1 Corinthians 9:22 teach about mission?	1 Cor 9:22	Short Answer

Explain the conflict between Jewish and Gentile believers.	Acts 15:1–11	Explanation
How did Paul adapt his message for the Athenians?	Acts 17:22–23	Explanation
Describe the challenges from idol worship in Ephesus.	Acts 19:23–27	Explanation
How can Paul's mission strategy apply in modern multicultural societies?	1 Cor 9:22	Critical Thinking
What are the dangers of adapting too much to culture?	Gal 2:16	Critical Thinking
How can Christians maintain unity despite cultural differences?	Gal 3:28	Critical Thinking
What does Ephesians 2:8–9 teach about salvation?	Eph 2:8–9	Bible Reflection
What lessons can you draw from Paul's perseverance?	2 Cor 11:23–27	Bible Reflection

SUMMARY

Paul's mission demonstrates that the gospel is for all people, in all cultures, at all times.
Faithful mission requires both cultural wisdom and theological courage.